

Halgic Research Integration Series

CANDOMBLÉ AND UMBANDA

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

Brazil — Beliefs, Rituals, and Traditions — From the African Roots to the Living Synthesis

From the African Roots to the Living Brazilian Synthesis.

Three centuries of slavery could not silence the axé of the terreiro.

The Orixás arrived across the water and never left.

*Umbanda was born in 1908 and declared that no spirit is inferior —
that the Preto Velho and the Caboclo carry as much sacred wisdom
as any ancient Orisha.*

Axé.

Contents

Introduction — Two Traditions, One Brazilian Sacred Story.....	3
African Roots — Yoruba, Fon, and Bantu in Brazil.....	4
Candomblé — The Tradition and Its Nations.....	5
The Ketu Nation — Yoruba Orishas in Brazil.....	5
The Major Orixás — The Seven of Source.....	7
Exu — Lord of the Crossroads.....	8
Yemanjá — Queen of the Sea.....	9
Oxum — Orixá of Sweet Waters and Love.....	10
Xangô — Thunder, Justice, and Royal Power.....	11
Ogum — Iron, Labor, and the Opening of Paths.....	12
Oxalá — The Creator and the White Cloth.....	13
Iansã / Oyá — Wind, Change, and the Threshold.....	14
Oxóssi — King of the Forest and the Hunt.....	15
Obaluaiê and Omolu — Lord of Disease and Cure.....	16
Nanã — The Oldest of the Elderly.....	17
Ossain — Lord of Leaves and Plant Medicine.....	18
Oxumaré — The Rainbow Serpent of Renewal.....	19
The Candomblé Terreiro — Sacred Community and Space.....	20
Candomblé Initiation — Feitura do Santo.....	21
Candomblé Ceremony — The Xirê.....	22
Axé — The Divine Power in Brazilian Practice.....	23
Candomblé Divination — Jogo de Búzios.....	24
Offerings, Ebó, and Ritual Reciprocity.....	25
How to Perform the Offerings — Step by Step.....	26
Sacred Foods and Ritual Preparation.....	27
The Birth of Umbanda — 1908 and the Brazilian Synthesis.....	28
Umbanda Cosmology — The Seven Lines of Force.....	29
The Umbanda Spirit Guides.....	30
Umbanda Ceremony — Structure and Practice.....	31
How to Perform the Umbanda Opening Ritual.....	32
Candomblé and Umbanda Today — Survival and Resistance.....	33
Haligricity Convergences.....	34

Introduction

Two Traditions, One Brazilian Sacred Story

Brazil is home to the most vibrant African diaspora sacred traditions outside Africa itself — a consequence of the largest slave trade in the Atlantic world (Brazil received approximately 4.9 million enslaved Africans, nearly half of all those transported across the Atlantic) and of the extraordinary tenacity with which African peoples preserved their sacred heritage under extreme persecution. The two primary traditions that emerged from this history — Candomblé and Umbanda — are distinct in origin, theology, and practice, but they are part of the same Brazilian sacred story.

Candomblé is the tradition of preservation: the effort to maintain the African sacred traditions — primarily the Yoruba Orisha religion, but also Dahomean Fon and Central African Bantu traditions — as close to their original form as possible in a New World context. The Candomblé communities of Bahia in northeastern Brazil achieved something extraordinary: they transmitted an essentially intact African religious tradition across three centuries of slavery, persecution, and oppression.

Umbanda is the tradition of synthesis: a 20th-century deliberate integration of Candomblé, Kardecist Spiritism, popular Catholicism, and Indigenous Brazilian spiritual practices. Umbanda emerged in the early 20th century as an explicitly Brazilian tradition — not an African tradition preserved in Brazil, but something new, born specifically from the Brazilian cultural experience. For Haligricity, Umbanda is uniquely significant: it may be the closest existing structural model to what Haligricity is doing — a deliberate, spiritually serious synthesis of multiple traditions into a coherent living practice.

African Roots

Yoruba, Fon, and Bantu in Brazil

The African peoples transported to Brazil came from multiple distinct cultural and linguistic groups across West and Central Africa. The three most important for the development of Brazilian sacred traditions were the Yoruba (from present-day Nigeria and Benin), the Fon and Ewe (from present-day Benin and Togo — the peoples of Dahomey who are the primary source of Haitian Vodou), and the Bantu-speaking peoples of Central Africa (from present-day Angola, Congo, and Mozambique).

The Yoruba were transported to Brazil primarily in the late 18th and early 19th centuries — the period of the Oyo Empire's collapse and the subsequent Yoruba civil wars. Concentrated in Bahia, the Yoruba (called Nagô in Brazil) brought the Orisha religion, the Ifa divination system, the sacred drum traditions, and the entire theological framework of the Yoruba world. The Bantu-speaking peoples brought the Nkisi and Inquices — the Bantu-tradition divine forces that appear in the Angola nation of Candomblé — along with a tradition of ancestor veneration and sacred objects (minkisi) containing concentrated divine power.

Candomblé

The Tradition and Its Nations (Nações)

Candomblé is not a single unified tradition but a family of related traditions organized into nations (nações) — each nation corresponding to a specific African ethnic origin and maintaining its own specific liturgical language, its own specific divine beings, and its own specific ceremonial forms. The major nations are Ketu (Yoruba origin, the most widely practiced), Angola (Bantu origin), Jeje (Fon-Ewe origin, closely related to Haitian Vodou), and several smaller nations including Efon, Ijexá, and Caboclo.

The three great Candomblé terreiros of Bahia — the Ilê Axé Iyá Nassô Oká (Casa Branca do Engenho Velho, founded approximately 1830), the Ilê Axé Opô Afonjá (founded 1910), and the Gantois (Ilê Iyá Omi Axé Iyamassê, founded approximately 1849) — are the sacred centers of the Ketu nation and among the most important sacred sites in the African diaspora world. They have been led for much of their history by women — the Mãe de Santo (Mother of the Saint), the female senior priestess whose authority within her terreiro is absolute.

The Ketu Nation

Yoruba Orishas in Brazil

The Ketu nation's preservation of the Yoruba Orisha tradition in Brazil is one of the most remarkable achievements in the history of world religion. Under slavery, with African religious practice illegal and Catholic baptism mandatory, the Candomblé communities of Bahia maintained not merely the general idea of the Orishas but specific sacred songs in Yoruba, specific sacred drum rhythms for specific Orixás, specific colors and sacred objects and foods and ritual protocols — details that require ongoing transmission from specialist to initiate to be maintained with any fidelity.

Preservation was achieved through the terreiro community — the tightly organized, hierarchical, family-like community of initiates centered on a senior priestess (Mãe de Santo) who carried the tradition's sacred knowledge and transmitted it to her initiates. The Candomblé community also used syncretism: identifying each Orixá with a Catholic saint, allowing public display of the sacred images under the guise of Catholic devotion. But Candomblé maintained a clear internal distinction: "The saints are the clothes the Orixás wear to go out in public." Inside the terreiro, the Orixás are addressed in their own names, in their own language.

The Major Orixás

The Seven of Source and the Full Pantheon

The Orixás of Candomblé are the same sacred beings as the Yoruba Orishas — same characters, same domains, same fundamental theological nature — expressed through the specific lens of Brazilian cultural experience. While the Yoruba tradition recognizes hundreds of Orishas, Brazilian Candomblé consolidated around a core pantheon of major Orixás who became the living heart of terreiro practice. Below are all the major Orixás, beginning with the foundational seven whose sections follow in detail, and including the complete remaining pantheon.

Exu

Lord of the Crossroads and Divine Communication

Exu is the first Orixá honored in every Candomblé ceremony — no communication between humans and Orixás is possible without Exu's cooperation. He is the Orixá of the crossroads, of all beginnings and endings, of speech, of the marketplace, of sexuality, and of the life force in its most raw and immediate form. He is not evil — the Christian missionaries who equated him with the Devil were expressing their fear of an Orixá whose function (opening all channels, including the dangerous ones) they could not accommodate within their theology.

In Brazilian practice, Exu has multiplied into a family: Exu Tiriri, Exu das Almas, Exu Veludo, Exu Marabô — each a specific aspect of the crossroads principle operating in a specific context. His colors are black and red. His number is seven. His offerings include red palm oil, rum, cigars, and raw meat at the crossroads. He is honored at the beginning of every ceremony with a specific rhythm on the agogô (iron bell) and specific songs that thank him and ask him to clear the path for the ceremony to follow.

Honoring Exu at Home

Place a small clay or iron figure of Exu at the entrance to your home or sacred space (never inside — he guards the threshold from outside). Offer a small glass of rum, a cigar (unlit is acceptable), and a coin. Light a candle — black or red. Address him: "Exu, guardian of the gateway, I honor your presence and ask that all paths be open for this work. Laroyê Exu!" The phrase "Laroyê Exu!" is his honorific greeting. This opening is not optional in the Candomblé understanding — without Exu's acknowledgment, no other sacred work proceeds.

Yemanjá

Queen of the Sea and Mother of All Waters

Yemanjá (Yemoja in Yoruba) is the mother of the sea in Brazilian Candomblé — the vast, encompassing, powerful mothering force of the ocean. She is the most publicly celebrated Orixá in Brazil: her February 2nd festival in Salvador and December 31st celebration in Rio de Janeiro are among the most attended public religious events in the country, when thousands of Brazilians carry offerings of white flowers, perfume, mirrors, and small boats to the sea's edge and release them toward her.

Yemanjá in Brazil has developed a specifically Brazilian dimension: she is understood as the mother of all the other Orixás (not just the sea creatures, as in the Yoruba tradition), and her relationship with the sea has deepened to encompass the vast, ambivalent, beautiful and dangerous character of the Atlantic Ocean that carried enslaved Africans to Brazil. She is at once the force that brought the ancestors across the water and the living memory of that crossing. Her colors are blue and white. Her number is seven. She loves mirrors, blue and white flowers, and perfume.

Offering to Yemanjá

On February 2nd or the full moon nearest the new year, go to the ocean, a river, or a large body of water. Prepare an offering of white flowers (roses, carnations), a small mirror, perfume, and a small white candle. Wade in to knee depth if possible. Light the candle. Hold the flowers and speak to her: "Yemanjá, mother of all waters, I bring these offerings with gratitude for your protection and with love for your children." Release the flowers into the water. Watch them move — the direction they travel is considered her response.

Oxum

Orixá of Sweet Waters, Love, Beauty, Gold, and Abundance

Oxum (Oshun in Yoruba) is the goddess of all sweet waters — rivers, waterfalls, springs — and of love, beauty, fertility, gold, and the abundance of life's sweetness. She is vain, sensuous, generous, and fierce when wronged. Her mythology contains one of the most important theological narratives in the Candomblé tradition: the story of how Oxum saved the world by seducing Ogum (who had retreated into the forest in rage, leaving humanity without iron tools) with honey, bringing him back to the community. Love, beauty, and sweetness are not frivolous — they are the forces that hold the world together.

In Brazil, Oxum is associated with the color gold and yellow, with brass mirrors and fans, with honey (her sacred food — always offered with a drop of oil and a request to make sure it has not gone bad before tasting), with freshwater fish, and with all forms of feminine beauty and creativity. She is the patroness of pregnant women and of all forms of abundance. Her greeting is "Ori ye ye o."

Ritual Bath to Oxum

Prepare a bath with fresh water, yellow rose petals, a spoonful of honey, a few drops of sweet perfume (vanilla, rose), and a pinch of gold glitter or a small piece of brass jewelry. Light a yellow candle. Before entering, pour a small amount on the ground with a brief prayer: "Ori ye ye o." Soak for at least fifteen minutes while holding your intention for what you are asking her to bless — love, creativity, abundance, healing of the womb. After the bath, do not dry yourself fully — let the water absorb into your skin.

Xangô

Orixá of Thunder, Justice, and Royal Power

Xangô (Shango in Yoruba) is the Orixá of thunder, lightning, and the fierce justice that punishes injustice wherever it is found. He was historically the fourth Alafin (king) of Oyo — deified after his death — and in Brazil he retains this royal character: dramatic, powerful, imperious, demanding of respect, and capable of extraordinary generosity to those who honor him properly. He governs the courts of law, the justice system, and all situations in which right must be separated from wrong.

Xangô's double axe (oxê) is his primary symbol. His colors are red and white. His sacred stone is the thunder stone (pedra de raio) — the prehistoric stone axes found in fields after lightning strikes, which the Yoruba-Brazilian tradition understands as literal lightning bolts solidified in the earth. His sacred food is amalá (corn paste cooked in palm oil). When facing a legal situation or injustice, light a red and white candle, state the situation clearly, and ask for his intervention. The key in working with Xangô is absolute honesty — he will not assist a case built on deception.

Ogum

Orixá of Iron, Labor, and the Opening of Paths

Ogum (Ogun in Yoruba) is the Orixá of iron — and through iron, of all tools, all technology, all labor, and all situations that require a path to be cut through resistance. He is the one who opens the way — before any new venture, any journey, any project requiring that something be cleared or opened, Ogum is invoked. He is the patron of soldiers, surgeons, farmers, mechanics, engineers, and anyone who works with metal and tools. The phrase "Ogum abre caminho" (Ogum opens the way) is one of the most commonly heard invocations in Candomblé and Umbanda.

His colors are dark blue or green and his metal is iron. He lives at the crossroads and in the forest — often near Exu, with whom he works closely. On a Monday (his day in many Brazilian practices), go to a crossroads with a small iron nail or piece of iron, a cigar or incense, and palm oil. State clearly what path you need opened: "Ogum, guardian of iron and the open way, I ask that you clear the path before me." Leave the nail, pour a few drops of palm oil. Walk away without looking back — this is important in Brazilian practice.

Oxalá

The Orixá of Creation, Peace, and Pure White Cloth

Oxalá (Obatala in Yoruba) is the eldest and most venerated of all Orixás in Candomblé — the Orixá of creation, of peace, of purity, and of white cloth. He is Olodumare's primary agent of creation — the one who shapes human bodies. He is also the Orixá of calm, of patience, of the wisdom that comes from the deepest experience. Oxalá has two primary aspects: Oxalá Velho (the old, serene, extremely ancient aspect — Oxalufã) and Oxalá Novo (the young, vigorous aspect — Oxaguiã).

His colors are pure white — only white is permitted at his ceremonies. On Fridays (his day), devotees wear white as a mark of devotion. He is honored by the washing of his sacred objects with clean cold water and by the offering of white corn, shea butter, and white foods. To honor Oxalá for peace and clarity: wear white on Fridays, prepare a bowl of white corn or white rice with shea butter and cool water on a white cloth. Light a white candle. Sit in silence for at least ten minutes before speaking. His work is slow — he asks for patience. Do not rush his counsel. And never offer him alcohol.

Iansã / Oyá

Orixá of Wind, Change, and the Threshold of Death

Iansã (Oyá in Yoruba) is the Orixá of the wind, of storms, of lightning alongside Xangô, and of the dead. She is the only Orixá who has no fear of death — she governs the threshold between life and death, escorts the dead on their journey, and is present at the moment of the body's final breath. She is fierce, independent, unpredictable, and magnificent — a warrior-woman who fights alongside Xangô and who cannot be controlled or contained by any force.

Her colors are copper/orange and dark red. She is honored at the cemetery gates and in situations requiring radical change — when something must be swept away to make room for what needs to come next. When facing a situation that needs radical change, on a Tuesday or Thursday (her days), go outside in windy weather if possible. Light a copper or orange candle. Speak to the wind: "Iansã, mother of winds, sweep through what must be cleared. Take what no longer serves." Her offering is a small piece of red fabric tied to a tree in the wind, or red wine poured on the earth at a cemetery entrance. Her sacred food is acarajé — the deep-fried black-eyed pea fritter that is both a sacred food of this Orixá and a symbol of Afro-Brazilian identity.

Oxóssi

King of the Forest and the Hunt

Oxóssi (Oshosi in Yoruba) is the Orixá of the hunt, the forest, and the abundance that comes from the natural world. He was the King of Keto — a Yoruba kingdom from which many enslaved Africans were taken to Brazil, which is why the Ketu nation bears his city's name. As the supreme hunter, Oxóssi governs all acts of strategic planning, of patient seeking, of finding what is needed. Hunters must be patient, observant, disciplined strategists — they cannot afford emotional impulsiveness. Oxóssi's gifts to those who work with him are clarity of strategy, the capacity to find and secure what is essential, and the abundance of the forest.

In the Umbanda system, Oxóssi governs the green line — the Linha de Oxóssi — which is the line of the Caboclos, the indigenous spirit guides who carry the forest's wisdom. His colors are light blue and green. His day is Thursday. His symbol is the ofá — the bow and arrow — the hunter's tool. His greeting is "Okê Arô!" (Hail to the forest!). He is the patron of good nutrition, of the satisfaction of essential needs, and of all who must track, plan, and secure what they need to sustain themselves and their communities.

Obaluaiê and Omolu

Lord of Disease, Healing, and the Earth's Secrets

Obaluaiê/Omolu is perhaps the most feared and most beloved Orixá in all of Candomblé — the Orixá of disease and its cure, of the earth itself, and of the secrets hidden beneath the ground. Obaluaiê and Omolu are two aspects of the same divine reality: Obaluaiê is the force that operates in epidemics and in the processes of disease, while Omolu is the guardian of the secrets of life and death, the one who receives those who depart. Together, they govern the most fundamental human vulnerability — illness, mortality, and the body's dissolution — and its counterpoint, the possibility of healing.

His body is always covered in raffia straw (the xaxará — his sacred scepter-like wand of woven straw and cowrie shells) — because his body bears the marks of the smallpox and disease he has survived and now governs. The covering is simultaneously a disguise and a proclamation: beneath the straw is the most complete knowledge of illness and its cure that any being possesses. Obaluaiê controls epidemics. He was invoked in the understanding of AIDS, of smallpox, of the great plagues. He was the Orixá called upon throughout the COVID-19 pandemic by terreiro communities in Brazil.

His colors are black, white, and red — specifically the pattern of straw, darkness, and the redness of infected skin. His day is Monday. His greeting is "Atotô Obaluaiê!" ("Quietly, Obaluaiê!" — because he must be approached with great care and respect). His foods include the ojiji — a preparation of roasted corn in palm oil. To work with Obaluaiê for healing: bring deep humility, complete honesty about the illness or difficulty, and patience — he does not work quickly, and he demands that the one seeking healing confront what they have been avoiding about their condition.

Nanã

The Oldest of the Elderly — Lady of the Primordial Waters

Nanã (Nanã Buruquê in full) is the oldest of all the Orixás — not merely the most ancient in the pantheon but the being who existed before the others, the primordial feminine whose muddy waters preceded the ocean that Yemanjá governs and the sweet rivers that Oxum inhabits. She dwells in swamps, in stagnant water, in the primordial mud from which the earth emerged. According to Candomblé mythology, it was Nanã who made the bodies of human beings — she took the clay of the primordial swamp and shaped the vessels into which life would be breathed. This makes her both the mother of the human body at its beginning and the one who receives that body back at its end. She governs both birth and death: she made the clay body, and the clay body returns to her.

Nanã is not approachable with iron — she predates the age of iron, which belongs to Ogum. No iron instruments are used in her ceremonies. Her sacred implement is the ibiri — a ceremonial bundle of palm stalks — which she carries as both a weapon and a symbol of the primal feminine authority. She is deeply patient, dignified, and ancient beyond reckoning. She is not sexual and rarely appears in the dramatic or fierce mode of younger Orixás. Her authority is the authority of the very beginning and the very end.

Her colors are dark blue, lilac, and white — the colors of deep water and the sky above swamplands. Her day is Monday. Her greeting is "Saluba Nanã!" She governs everything that is most primordial: the clay of the body, the memory of the beginning, and the dissolution at the end. She is the Orixá called upon when what is needed is not power or action but deep, primordial resting — when the practitioner needs to return to the source before proceeding.

Ossain

Lord of Leaves and Plant Medicine

Ossain (Ossaim, Osanyin in Yoruba) is the Orixá of leaves, of herbs, and of all plant medicine. The Yoruba saying "Kó sì ewè, kó sì Òrìṣà" — "Without leaf, there is no Orisha" — is the central theological statement of his domain: no ceremony in Candomblé can be performed without the specific sacred leaves and herbs whose axé (divine power) is under Ossain's governance. Every ritual bath, every preparation of sacred food, every healing preparation, every initiation — all require specific leaves, and those leaves must be properly requested from Ossain before they are gathered.

Ossain received from Olodumare the secret of the leaves — their names, their properties, their capacity to bring calm or vigor, luck or misfortune, glory or illness. The other Orixás do not have power over any plant; they depend on Ossain to maintain their health and for the success of their initiatives. His knowledge of leaves is the most closely guarded sacred knowledge in Candomblé — transmitted only to the Baba Ewe (father of leaves), his specialist priest. His symbol is an iron staff with seven prongs radiating upward from the top, with a bird at the center — the bird being the repository of his secret knowledge.

His colors are green and white. His day is Thursday. His greeting is "Ewé Ô!" (referring to the leaves — ewé — that are his domain). Because his knowledge is the foundation on which all other sacred practice rests, Ossain occupies a paradoxically central position in Candomblé: he is not one of the most frequently discussed Orixás in popular accounts of the tradition, but without his domain — the healing, activating, axé-carrying properties of specific plants — none of the other Orixás can work.

Oxumaré

The Rainbow Serpent — Orixá of Renewal and Cyclical Motion

Oxumaré is the Orixá of the rainbow and the serpent — the sacred being who embodies the principle of cyclical renewal, of movement between opposites, of the endless rotation of existence. The rainbow connects earth and sky; the serpent moves between worlds; Oxumaré is the living principle that holds these connections in motion. He/she is explicitly dual-gendered — spending six months of the year as male and six months as female, embodying the cosmic principle that all polarities are aspects of one underlying reality in motion.

Oxumaré governs all cyclical processes: the turning of seasons, the cycles of the body, the rhythm of wealth and scarcity, the movement of wealth through communities. He is associated with snakes and with the rainbow's colors — a cascade of color. Oxumaré's presence signals transformation, renewal, and the recognition that what appears to end is only cycling into its next form. He is the child of Nanã, born of the primordial feminine, and belongs to the family of Orixás that includes Obaluaiê and Ossain — the Orixás of deep transformation. His greeting is "Arroboboi Oxumaré!"

The Candomblé Terreiro

Sacred Community and Space

The terreiro is the sacred community of Candomblé — not merely a physical place but a community of initiated practitioners organized under a senior priestess (Mãe de Santo) or priest (Pai de Santo) who is the terreiro's spiritual head, sacred knowledge keeper, and primary vehicle for the Orixás. The terreiro is simultaneously a religious community, an extended family, a healing center, and a sacred institution that preserves the African heritage.

A traditional Candomblé terreiro includes: the barracão (the main ceremony hall where xirê ceremonies take place and where the Orixás descend into their "horses"), the peji or quarto de santo (the inner sanctuary where the Orixás' sacred objects are housed — accessible only to initiates), the roncó (the initiation chamber, sealed during initiations), individual houses or shrines for specific Orixás, and the axé point — the sacred spot where the concentrated spiritual force of the tradition resides, often near a specific tree or stone.

The terreiro is organized in a strict hierarchy based on initiation seniority. The Mãe de Santo or Pai de Santo is the unchallenged spiritual authority. The equede (female initiated who does not receive the Orixás but serves them) and the ogã (male initiated who does not receive but plays the sacred drums) are specialized roles. The filhos and filhas de santo (sons and daughters of the saint) are the general initiate community; the iaô is the newest initiate — in their year of restricted practice, wearing white.

Candomblé Initiation

Feitura do Santo — The Making of the Saint

The *feitura do santo* (making of the saint — "saint" here meaning the initiate's head Orixá) is the central transformative event of Candomblé practice — the multi-week process through which a person's head is formally opened to receive their Orixá and through which they become a member of the *terreiro* community with specific sacred obligations and identity.

Bori — The Initial Head Feeding

Before full initiation, the candidate undergoes the *bori* (feeding the head — *ori* in Yoruba, *ori* being the personal divine nature within the head). The *bori* is a ceremony in which specific offerings are made directly to the person's *Ori* — the divine spark within them — to strengthen, cleanse, and prepare their head to receive the Orixá. The *bori* may be performed multiple times over years before full initiation. It is the foundational practice of Candomblé — the recognition that before working with the cosmic Orixás, the practitioner must attend to and strengthen their own inner divine nature.

Personal Bori Practice — Head Feeding for Clarity and Strength

This simplified *bori* is for home practice and self-preparation. It is not a substitute for the full ceremonial *bori* performed within a *terreiro*.

1. Prepare: white cloth for your head, a small bowl, cool water, shea butter (*ori*), white corn or white rice, and a white candle.
2. Sit quietly and place the white cloth on your head. Breathe deeply. Feel the weight and warmth at the crown of your head — this is the seat of your *Ori*.
3. Speak to your *Ori*: "Ori mi, I honor the divine presence within me. I feed you with love and ask for clarity, strength, and alignment with my true path."
4. Take a small amount of shea butter and anoint the top of your head, gently rubbing in a small circle. Then anoint your forehead, temples, and the back of your neck.
5. Place a small amount of white corn or rice in the bowl. Add a pinch of shea butter and a few drops of cool water. This is the symbolic feeding.
6. Sit with the candle lit for at least fifteen minutes, holding your intention — clarity, healing, strengthening, alignment.
7. After the practice, eat something white — rice, coconut, white bean — to complete the feeding through the body.

Candomblé Ceremony

The Xirê — How to Understand and Participate

The xirê (from the Yoruba word for play or celebration — *shèrè*) is the primary public ceremony of Candomblé — the gathering of the terreiro community for drumming, sacred song, and the invocation of the Orixás, culminating in the possession of initiated devotees by their Orixás, who then dance, distribute blessings, and receive offerings.

Structure of the Xirê

OPENING (Padê):

The ceremony begins before the community enters the barracão with the padê — the honoring of Exu. Specific songs and a specific rhythm on the agogô (iron bell) thank Exu and ask him to clear the path. This separation of Exu from the ceremonial space is not a removal but a positioning: Exu is sent to the threshold, to guard the entrance, while the ceremony proceeds within.

CALL TO THE ORIXÁS:

The assembly enters the barracão. The drummers begin. The filhos de santo form a circle (the roda) and begin to sing and move in sequence through each Orixá's specific songs — starting with Oxalá and proceeding through the full sequence. Each Orixá has a specific sequence of three songs in most traditions — the first calls them, the second invites them more strongly, the third is the moment of greatest intensity.

THE DESCENTS:

As the appropriate songs are sung and appropriate rhythms played, initiated devotees whose head Orixá is being called may begin to receive that Orixá. The equede assist — supporting those receiving, helping them dress in the Orixá's specific costume. The manifested Orixás dance in the barracão — each with their specific movements, costume, and character. They move through the community, blessing specific people, receiving offerings. Some Orixás speak; some do not.

CLOSING:

The Orixás depart. Specific closing songs are sung. The community shares food.

Axé

The Divine Power in Brazilian Practice

Axé (pronounced Ah-SHAY — the Portuguese transliteration of the Yoruba Ashe) is the foundational sacred power concept of Candomblé and Umbanda — the divine creative force that flows from the Orixás through the terreiro community, through sacred objects, through properly performed ritual, and through the practitioners who have cultivated their relationship with the sacred adequately to serve as vehicles.

Axé is simultaneously: the sacred power itself, the affirmation spoken at the end of prayers and ceremonial declarations (equivalent to Amen, Ashe, So be it), the name for the concentrated sacred force housed in the terreiro's foundational objects, and the general quality of effective sacred force in a person, place, or object. In Candomblé and Umbanda ceremony, "Axé!" is used at the end of prayers to affirm that the sacred force is present and active, as a greeting between practitioners, and as an acknowledgment of something powerfully true or beautiful.

In Haligrity, this is the same word used as Ashe — same pronunciation (Ah-SHAY), same Yoruba root, same theological meaning. The Brazilian form is simply the Portuguese phonetic spelling of the same living sacred force.

Candomblé Divination

Jogo de Búzios — The Shell Game

The jogo de búzios (game of shells) is the primary divination system of Candomblé — a direct descendant of the Yoruba tradition of casting cowrie shells (ibìl or dilogun). Sixteen shells are used, each with the top cut so that it has an open face (boca aberta — open mouth) and a closed back. When cast, each shell falls either mouth up (open — positive) or mouth down (closed — negative). The number of shells falling mouth up determines the Odu that is speaking to the querent's situation.

The reader casts the sixteen shells on a special mat after cooling them in their hands, blowing sacred breath on them, and asking the Orixás and the querent's Ori to speak clearly. The count of open shells reveals the Odu: 16 open (Odù — the Orixá Odudua speaks; a sacred rare sign); 8 open speaks of Yemanjá (abundance and protection); 5 open speaks of Oxum (love, money, healing); 1 open speaks of Exu (everything possible, choose carefully). Each count then undergoes additional throws to determine the specific message and the appropriate offering (ebó) to address the situation.

Offerings, Ebó, and Ritual Reciprocity

The ebó (offering, sacrifice) is the primary ritual technology of Candomblé — the material expression of the practitioner's side of the sacred exchange that sustains the relationship between human beings and the Orixás. The Orixás give their power, their protection, their guidance, and their presence. The practitioners give offerings: food, drink, light (candles), flowers, sacred objects, and in specific ceremonial contexts, the life force of sacrificed animals.

Offering in Candomblé is not bribery and not supplication in the sense of begging a more powerful being for a favor. It is reciprocity — the acknowledgment of a relationship of mutual exchange and the maintenance of that relationship through the material expression of gratitude, devotion, and the desire for continued connection.

How to Perform the Offerings

Step by Step

The following practical guides are for making offerings to the Orixás accessible to any sincere practitioner. Full initiation changes the nature and scope of what is appropriate, but these foundational practices are available to all.

Basic Offering Practice — For Any Orixá

1. Clean the space. Physical cleanliness is the first step — the Orixás do not come to dirty places.
2. Light the candle in the Orixá's color. This signals that you are opening sacred space.
3. Pour a small amount of water on the ground or floor before the altar. This grounds the energy and acknowledges the earth.
4. Prepare the food offering on the plate. It should be the best quality you can offer — not leftovers.
5. Place the plate before the candle. Hold your hands over it briefly and speak your intention clearly.
6. Address the Orixá by name. State what you are offering and why. State what you are asking. Be specific and be honest.
7. Leave the offering in place until the candle burns out naturally. Do not blow out the candle.
8. After the candle is done, dispose of the food offering respectfully — taken to the appropriate location for that Orixá: Yemanjá's offerings to the water, Exu's to the crossroads, Oxalá's at the foot of a white tree or on clean earth.

Orixá Offering Quick Reference

Exu: red and black candle | rum or cachaça | cigars | crossroads location

Yemanjá: blue and white candle | white flowers, perfume, mirrors | river or sea edge

Oxum: yellow or gold candle | honey, yellow flowers, brass fan | river or waterfall

Xangô: red and white candle | amalá (cornmeal in palm oil) | red wine | hilltop or tree

Ogum: dark blue or green candle | palm oil | iron objects | crossroads or forest edge

Oxalá: white candle only | white food, shea butter | NEVER alcohol | foot of white tree

Iansã: copper or orange candle | red wine | red fabric tied to tree | cemetery gate or windy hilltop

Oxóssi: green or blue candle | forest fruits, game meats, corn | forest or green outdoor space

Obaluaiê: black, white, and red candle | roasted corn in palm oil | earth, cemetery | with deep humility

Nanã: dark blue or purple candle | white food, no iron | still water or swamp location

Ossain: green and white candle | specific leaves gathered with permission | forest or garden space

Sacred Foods and Ritual Preparation

Food is sacred technology in Candomblé — not merely sustenance but the primary material vehicle for the Orixás' force, the medium through which axé is transmitted to the community. Before preparing sacred food: wash your hands thoroughly (mandatory and sacred, not merely hygienic); wear white or clean clothing; set a clear intention; do not taste the food before offering it — it belongs to the Orixá first; do not prepare sacred food when in a state of anger, grief, or significant emotional disturbance; cook with attention — sacred food preparation is a meditative act.

The amalá (Xangô's sacred food): cook cornmeal with water until thick. Add palm oil (dendê) — a generous amount. The dendê oil is what makes it Xangô's. Serve warm on a round plate. This dish is the most widely prepared sacred food in Candomblé and can be offered to Xangô at any significant moment — legal situations, situations of injustice, situations requiring royal power.

The Birth of Umbanda

1908 and the Brazilian Synthesis

Umbanda was born on November 15, 1908 — according to the most widely accepted founding narrative — in the city of Niterói near Rio de Janeiro. A young man named Zélio de Moraes, ill and unresponsive to medical treatment, was brought to a Kardecist Spiritist session. In the session, Zélio was possessed not by a European spirit (as Kardecist Spiritism typically expected) but by a caboclo — the spirit of an indigenous Brazilian man — who announced himself as the Caboclo das Sete Encruzilhadas (the Caboclo of the Seven Crossroads). When the session leader objected to the appearance of an "inferior" spirit, the Caboclo responded that there were no inferior spirits — that all souls in their development were worthy of respect. He announced that a new religion would be founded the following day, one that honored all the traditions of Brazil without hierarchy.

Umbanda is deliberately syncretic — it synthesizes Candomblé's Orisha tradition with Kardecist Spiritism's spirit-communication framework, popular Catholicism's saints, and the traditions of indigenous Brazil. Umbanda may be the closest existing structural model to what Haligrlicity is doing: deliberately synthesized from multiple traditions, organized around practical service rather than doctrinal purity, open to practitioners from all backgrounds, continuously evolving, understood as a living tradition rather than a historical one.

Umbanda Cosmology

The Seven Lines of Force

Umbanda organizes the divine world through the Seven Lines of Force (Sete Linhas) — seven primary streams of sacred energy, each governed by an Orixá and containing multiple spirit guides who work under that Orixá's vibration.

Linha de Oxalá (White Line): peace, healing, spiritual evolution, the highest spiritual guidance. Linha de Yemanjá (Blue Line): the waters, motherhood, emotional healing, family healing. Linha de Xangô (Red Line): justice, truth, the law, the destruction of falsehood. Linha de Oxóssi (Green Line): the forest, nature, hunting, abundance, indigenous wisdom — the Caboclos work in this line. Linha de Ogum (Blue-Red Line): the opening of paths, protection, and the removal of obstacles. Linha de Exu (Black and Red Line): communication between worlds, crossroads, and the transformation of difficult situations — the Exus and Pomba-Giras work here. Linha das Almas (Purple Line): the dead, the souls in development, the healing of grief — the Pretos Velhos work here.

The Umbanda Spirit Guides

Preto Velho / Preta Velha — The Old Black Ones

The Preto Velho (male) and Preta Velha (female) are the spirit guides most beloved in all of Umbanda — the spirits of enslaved Africans who lived, suffered, and developed extraordinary spiritual wisdom through the experience of Brazilian slavery. They manifest in ceremony as very old, slow-moving, tobacco-smoking elders who move carefully, speak gently, and listen with complete, unhurried attention. Their wisdom is the wisdom of extreme suffering transformed into compassion — they have seen the worst that human beings can do to each other and they have emerged not bitter but profoundly loving.

The Preto Velho is the counselor of Umbanda. His pipe is sacred — the smoke carries prayers. Working with Preto Velho: light a white or purple candle, light a cigar if you have one and allow the smoke to rise as an offering. Speak to him as you would to a wise elder: with respect, with directness, and with complete honesty about your situation. He does not respond to elaborate requests — he responds to genuine need and genuine honesty. His characteristic phrase in ceremony is "Minha filha" or "Meu filho" (my daughter, my son) — terms of endearment that carry the weight of an elder's unconditional love.

Caboclo / Cabocla — The Indigenous Guides

The Caboclos are the spirit guides of indigenous Brazilian peoples. They manifest as powerful, sometimes brusque, direct figures who move with the energy of the forest — strong, clear, uninterested in social niceties, intensely present. Their knowledge of medicinal plants (the domain that overlaps with Ossain's sacred herbalism), of the forest's sacred geography, and of the specific healing practices of indigenous tradition is their gift to those who work with them. Working with Caboclo: go outdoors if possible, light a green candle or forest incense (cedar, copal). Speak clearly and without preamble — the Caboclo has no patience for elaborate social performance. State your situation directly.

Exu and Pomba-Gira — The Crossroads Workers

The Umbanda Exus and Pomba-Giras are the most misunderstood figures in the tradition — routinely portrayed as demonic by evangelical critics, but completely different from this portrayal. Exu in Umbanda works with difficult situations that the more elevated guides cannot or will not address: addictions, dangerous relationships, situations involving the less spiritually developed aspects of human life. He is not evil: he is the sacred force that operates in the shadow zones of human experience where the light has not yet reached, and he transforms what he finds there rather than condemning it. The Pomba-Gira (female Exu energy) is the spirit of feminine power in its most assertive, most sensuous, most transgressive expression — the woman who refuses to be diminished, the force of feminine desire in its completeness. They get things done.

Umbanda Ceremony

Structure and Practice

Umbanda ceremony (gira — a word meaning turning or circulation, describing the rotation of spiritual energy through the ceremony) is more accessible and less formally restricted than Candomblé ceremony — it is one of Umbanda's fundamental principles that the sacred should be accessible to all, regardless of initiation level.

The gira begins with Catholic prayers (Our Father, Hail Mary, the Apostles' Creed) — Umbanda's formal acknowledgment of its Catholic dimension. Then the opening song (ponto de abertura) for the line of spirits being called. The mediums (médiuns) who are incorporated by the spirit guides stand in a line or circle. As the specific songs and rhythms for each spirit guide are sung and played, the mediums begin to receive their guides. The spirit guides, once manifested, work directly with community members who queue to receive their counsel — the Preto Velho listens and offers advice, the Caboclo may perform a healing gesture, the Exu may deliver a specific instruction. The session ends with the spirit guides departing, specific closing prayers, and the mediums returning to ordinary consciousness.

How to Perform the Umbanda Opening Ritual

Umbanda Home Opening — For Personal Practice

This is the foundational Umbanda practice for any personal sacred work. What you need: white candle, glass of water, incense (sandalwood or frankincense), small offering of food for Exu at the threshold (small piece of bread, a coin, a cigar if you have one).

STEP 1 — THE THRESHOLD: Place Exu's offering at the door or threshold of your space before entering. This sends Exu to the threshold to guard — outside the space, not inside.

STEP 2 — CLEANSE THE SPACE: Light the incense and walk through the space counterclockwise, letting the smoke reach every corner. Say: "I cleanse this space of all that does not serve the work of love and light. I ask that only forces of elevation and healing be present here."

STEP 3 — THE GLASS OF WATER: Place a glass of fresh water on any altar or table. A glass of clean water, refreshed daily, is the minimum Umbanda home practice — one of the most simple and most powerful.

STEP 4 — LIGHT THE WHITE CANDLE: Light the candle for Oxalá and sing or speak: "Saravá Oxalá! Saravá todos os Guias!" (Honor to Oxalá! Honor to all the Guides!)

STEP 5 — CALL YOUR GUIDES: Sit quietly. Breathe deeply seven times. Open your awareness to any impressions, images, or feelings that arise. Stay with this awareness for at least ten minutes.

STEP 6 — STATE YOUR INTENTION: Speak clearly what you are working on — what healing, what guidance, what transformation you are seeking. Be specific.

STEP 7 — CLOSE: When ready to close, say: "Saravá! I thank all the guides who have been present. I close this space with love and gratitude. Axé!" Extinguish the candle (snuff, do not blow — breath disturbs the spiritual atmosphere).

Candomblé and Umbanda Today

Survival and Resistance

Both Candomblé and Umbanda are thriving — and both are under severe and escalating pressure. In 2024, Brazil recorded nearly a 70 percent year-on-year increase in cases of discrimination and attacks on Afro-Brazilian religious practices, according to the Ministry of Human Rights. The main victims are Umbanda and Candomblé practitioners. The violence ranges from derogatory name-calling and social media harassment to the physical destruction of terreiros, arson, and in documented cases, homicide. In gang-controlled favelas in Rio de Janeiro, simply wearing the religious garb of Candomblé or Umbanda has been declared a crime by evangelical criminal factions, punishable by expulsion.

The most dramatic example in recent years: on January 10, 2025 — in the days leading up to the National Day of Religious Tolerance (January 21) — a group of approximately 100 evangelicals from the Assembly of God church disrupted a ritual at the Terreiro Xambá in Olinda, one of the oldest Candomblé terreiros in the region and the last remaining terreiro of the Xambá nation in Latin America. The attack occurred during a ceremony to Obaluaíê — the Orixá of disease and healing — a targeting whose theological dimensions were not lost on practitioners.

The National Day of Religious Tolerance (January 21) was established in 2007 in honor of Mãe Gilda (Gildásia dos Santos e Santos) — the Candomblé Mãe de Santo who founded the Ilê Axé Abassá de Ogum terreiro in Salvador, Bahia, and who died on January 21, 2000, her health destroyed by the stress of sustained religious persecution. The Universal Church of the Kingdom of God had published articles calling her a "charlatan" alongside her photograph without consent; vandals burned her terreiro; she suffered verbal and physical attacks. Her daughter filed a lawsuit that resulted in a 2009 conviction. Her death and legacy gave Brazil its official day against religious intolerance.

The acarajé — the deep-fried black-eyed pea fritter traditionally associated with Iansã and sold by Baianas (women in white lace dresses and headwraps) — has become a specific battleground. Evangelical vendors have been selling acarajé under names like "El Shaddai" or "Acarajé do Senhor" (Acarajé of the Lord), explicitly declaring that the traditional name is spiritually tainted. Evangelical pastors have invoked 1 Corinthians 10:21 — "You cannot drink the cup of the Lord and the cup of demons" — to declare acarajé sinful. Candomblé scholars and priests call this "religious racism" — a systematic attempt to erase the Afro-Brazilian sacred dimension from Brazilian culinary and cultural identity.

Despite everything, the traditions persist. Umbanda continues to spread internationally — with significant communities in Uruguay, Argentina, and growing interest in Europe and North America. Candomblé's three great Bahian terreiros continue their initiations, their xirê ceremonies, and their transmission of the tradition. The Orixás continue to descend.

Haligrity Convergences

Axé and Ashe — The Same Word in Two Languages

Axé in Candomblé and Umbanda is the same word as Ashe in Yoruba and Haligrity — the same Yoruba root, the same theological meaning (the divine creative power flowing from the supreme source through specific divine forces into all of creation), the same use as a closing affirmation (Ah-SHAY). The Brazilian traditions confirm what the Yoruba tradition established: this word carries real sacred weight, and its use in the Haligric meal blessing and sacred language practices is not a borrowing of an exotic sound but an invocation of a specific, ancient, living sacred force.

Umbanda as Structural Model for Haligrity

Umbanda may be the closest existing model to what Haligrity is doing: a deliberate, spiritually serious synthesis of multiple traditions organized around practical service rather than doctrinal purity, open to all practitioners rather than restricted by ethnic or initiatory lineage, continuously evolving rather than fixed, and understood as a living tradition rather than a historical one. The comparison is not about content — Haligrity is not Umbanda. It is about structure: both are genuine syntheses that take the sacred seriously while refusing the exclusivity of any single tradition.

The Bori and Haligric Self-Preparation

Candomblé's bori practice — the feeding of the head (Ori), the strengthening and clarification of the personal divine nature within each practitioner, as the foundational practice before any other sacred work — is the West African-Brazilian articulation of what Haligrity holds about self-preparation. Before the practitioner can serve as a genuine vehicle for sacred force, their own inner nature must be attended to. The bori is the ritualized form of this recognition.

The Complete Pantheon and the Multiple Faces of the Sacred

The Candomblé pantheon — with its Orixás governing every domain of human experience from disease (Obaluaíê) to plant medicine (Ossain) to the primordial feminine (Nanã) to cyclical renewal (Oxumaré) to strategic planning (Oxóssi) — demonstrates the sacred wholeness of a tradition that has not fragmented the divine into the acceptable and the unacceptable. Obaluaíê governs the epidemic. Ossain governs the cure. Nanã makes the body. Oxumaré cycles it through transformation. Iansã escorts it at the threshold. The same divine reality holds all of this without contradiction — and the Haligric practitioner who honors the full range of the Orixás is practicing a sacred cosmology that leaves nothing out.

The Preto Velho and the Ancestor Dimension

The Preto Velho — the spirit of the enslaved African elder who has transformed extreme suffering into profound compassion and is now available as a guide for those who seek genuine wisdom — is one of the most moving spirit guide figures in the global sacred tradition. The wisdom earned through the worst suffering, offered freely and without bitterness: this is the deepest teaching of the ancestor relationship in any tradition. The Haligric ancestor altar holds this same recognition.

*"Saravá Oxalá! Saravá todos os Guias!
Honor to Oxalá! Honor to all the Guides!"*

— Umbanda opening salutation

Three hundred years of persecution could not silence the axé of the African terreiro. Umbanda was born in 1908 and declared that no spirit is inferior — that the Preto Velho and the Caboclo carry as much sacred wisdom as any ancient Orisha. Both traditions confirm the same truth that Haligrity holds: the sacred is not the exclusive property of any single tradition, the divine meets us in the specific forms we are capable of receiving, and synthesis — when it is genuine, when it is spiritually serious, when it serves real communities with real sacred power — is not dilution. It is the next form that the living tradition takes. Axé. Grand Rising.